1.5.2 BDD works best in an Agile or iterative context

BDD requirements-analysis practices assume that it's difficult, if not impossible, to define the requirements completely upfront, and that these will evolve as the team (and the stakeholders) learn more about the project. This approach is naturally more in line with an Agile or iterative project methodology.

1.5.3 BDD doesn't work well in a silo

In many larger organizations, a siloed development approach is still the norm. Detailed specifications are written by business analysts and then handed off to development teams that are often offsite or offshore. Similarly, testing is delegated to another, totally separate, QA team. In organizations like this, it's still possible to practice BDD at a coding level, and development teams will still be able to expect significant increases in code quality, better design, more maintainable code, and fewer defects. But the lack of interaction between the business analyst teams and the developers will make it harder to use BDD practices to progressively clarify and understand the real requirements.

Similarly, siloed testing teams can be a challenge. If the QA team waits until the end of the project to intervene, or does so in isolation, they'll miss their chance to contribute to requirements earlier on, which results in wasted effort spent fixing issues that could have been found earlier and fixed more easily. Automating the acceptance criteria is also much more beneficial if the QA team participates in defining, and possibly automating, the scenarios.

1.5.4 Poorly written tests can lead to higher test-maintenance costs

Creating automated acceptance tests, particularly for complex web applications, requires a certain skill, and many teams starting to use BDD find this a significant challenge. Indeed, if the tests aren't carefully designed, with the right levels of abstraction and expressiveness, they run the risk of being fragile. And if there are a large number of poorly written tests, they'll certainly be hard to maintain. Plenty of organizations have successfully implemented automated acceptance tests for complex web applications, but it takes know-how and experience to get it right. We'll look at techniques for doing this later on in the book.

1.6 Summary

In this chapter you were introduced to Behavior-Driven Development. Among other things, you learned the following:

- Successful projects need to build software that's reliable and bug-free and to build features that deliver real value to the business.
- BDD practitioners use conversations about concrete examples to build up a common understanding of what features will deliver real value to the organization.
- These examples form the basis of the acceptance criteria that developers use to determine when a feature is done.